Platform9 Jailbreak

Escape the Managed KVM Trap

Migrate from Platform9 Managed OpenStack/KVM to Self-Managed KVM with hyper2kvm + hypersdk

"Your VMs. Your infrastructure. Your freedom."

The Platform9 Lock-In Problem

You own the hardware. You own the VMs. Why are you paying someone else to manage them?

Recurring Fees

Platform9 charges per-node per-month for the privilege of managing YOUR hardware. At ~$250/node/month for the Freedom tier, a 50-node cluster costs $150,000/year — for a management layer on top of open-source KVM.

Control Plane Dependency

Platform9's cloud-hosted control plane manages your on-prem nodes. If Platform9 experiences an outage, or if you stop paying, your management interface disappears. Your VMs keep running, but you lose visibility and control.

Limited Customization

Platform9 abstracts away libvirt and KVM behind their own API. You cannot customize VM XML configs, use advanced libvirt features like NUMA pinning or PCI passthrough, or integrate with your own automation tooling directly.

Vendor Lock-In

Migrating away from Platform9 requires re-exporting all VMs, rebuilding domain configurations, and losing Platform9-specific metadata and networking setup. The longer you stay, the deeper the lock-in.

The irony: Platform9 runs on top of open-source KVM and OpenStack. You're paying a premium for a management layer over software that is already free. The question isn't whether you *can* self-manage — it's whether you have the right migration tooling to make the switch painless.

The Escape Path — hyper2kvm + hypersdk

A four-step jailbreak from Platform9 to self-managed KVM freedom.

1
Export VMs

Use hypersdk's OpenStack provider adapter to export VMs from Platform9. Parallel export with live progress streaming. No Platform9 API required — goes straight to the OpenStack layer underneath.

2
Convert & Fix

hyper2kvm's VMCraft engine performs offline disk manipulation: driver injection, initramfs regeneration, fstab UUID stabilization, GRUB repair. No libguestfs appliance needed.

3
Deploy

Deploy to self-managed KVM/libvirt with auto-generated domain XML, or to KubeVirt for cloud-native VM management. One pipeline, dual targets.

4
Monitor

Use the hyper2kvm web dashboard with 20+ VM panels for full visibility. No Platform9 dependency. No cloud control plane. Everything runs on your infrastructure.

Why This Works

Platform9 is built on OpenStack + KVM. Under the hood, your VMs are already KVM guests managed by libvirt. The Platform9 layer adds an abstraction you don't need. hyper2kvm + hypersdk peel off that layer, give you direct libvirt access, and provide a web dashboard that replaces Platform9's management UI — without the monthly bill.

Feature Comparison

Side-by-side capabilities: what you get with Platform9 vs. what you get after the jailbreak.

Capability	Platform9	hyper2kvm + hypersdk
VM management	✓ (their dashboard)	✓ (web dashboard, 20+ panels)
KVM/libvirt control	Abstracted (limited)	✓ Full access (virsh, XML, API)
Cost	~$250/node/month	$0 (Apache-2.0)
Air-gap support	✕ (cloud control plane required)	✓ Fully offline capable
KubeVirt support	Partial	✓ Full lifecycle
Multi-cloud export	✕	✓ 10 clouds via hypersdk
Guest agent insights	✕	✓ OS, filesystems, processes
Security analysis	Basic	✓ Exposure scoring
VM disk management	Basic	✓ Hot-plug attach/detach/CDROM
Auto disk cleanup	✕	✓ Threshold-based
Credential store	Their own	✓ Persisted, auto-reconnect
Capacity planning	✕	✓ Gauges, top consumers
VM create/clone/resize	✓	✓ CLI + web + API
Open source	✕ Proprietary	✓ Apache-2.0

Cost Savings Analysis

Three-year total cost of ownership for a 50-node deployment.

Item	Platform9 (50 nodes)	hyper2kvm + hypersdk
License Year 1	$150,000	$0
License Year 2	$150,000	$0
License Year 3	$150,000	$0
Support	Included	Community (free) or commercial
Migration tooling	Built-in (to Platform9 only)	Built-in (any target)
3-Year Total	$450,000	$0
Savings	—	$450,000 (100%)

Platform9 pricing is approximately $250/node/month for the Freedom tier. Actual pricing varies by contract size, commitment term, and negotiated discounts. Contact Platform9 for a current quote.

What $450K Buys Instead

More Hardware

$450K buys 15-20 additional servers. Expand capacity instead of paying management fees on existing infrastructure.

Engineering Talent

$450K funds 2-3 full-time engineers for a year. Build internal expertise instead of outsourcing to a vendor.

Training & Certification

Train your entire ops team on KVM, libvirt, and Kubernetes. Invest in people, not licenses.

Other Projects

Redirect budget to modernization initiatives, security hardening, or developer tooling that creates competitive advantage.

What You Get After Jailbreak

A side-by-side view of life before and after escaping Platform9.

Before (Platform9)

- ✕ Cloud-dependent control plane
- ✕ Pay-per-node recurring fees ($250/node/month)
- ✕ Limited API — Platform9 abstractions only
- ✕ Vendor lock-in — proprietary management layer
- ✕ No offline / air-gap operation
- ✕ No direct libvirt XML customization
- ✕ No PCI passthrough or NUMA pinning control
- ✕ Outage risk tied to Platform9 cloud availability
- ✕ Migration tooling only works into Platform9

After (hyper2kvm + hypersdk)

- ✓ Self-managed KVM — nothing phones home
- ✓ Zero licensing cost (Apache-2.0)
- ✓ Full libvirt API — virsh, XML, direct qemu access
- ✓ No vendor lock-in — open source, portable
- ✓ Air-gap capable — runs fully offline
- ✓ Web dashboard with 20+ VM management panels
- ✓ KubeVirt + libvirt dual deploy from same pipeline
- ✓ Guest agent insights, security scoring, disk management
- ✓ 10-cloud export via hypersdk (migrate from anywhere)

Key insight: After the jailbreak, you still have all the functionality Platform9 provided — VM lifecycle management, monitoring, a web dashboard — but you also gain capabilities Platform9 never offered: full libvirt control, air-gap operation, multi-cloud migration, and the freedom to customize everything. All for $0/year.

hypersdk — The Export Engine

The Go-based daemon that extracts your VMs from Platform9 and 9 other cloud platforms.

10 Cloud Provider Adapters

OpenStack (Platform9's underlying layer), VMware vSphere, AWS, Azure, GCP, Hyper-V, OCI, Alibaba Cloud, Proxmox — and the list grows. Hexagonal architecture makes adding providers straightforward.

Parallel VM Export

Export multiple VMs simultaneously with live progress streaming. No need to wait for one export to finish before starting the next. Dramatically reduces total migration time for large fleets.

Carbon-Aware Scheduling

Schedule resource-intensive export operations during low-carbon-intensity windows. Meet ESG commitments while migrating. A capability no other migration tool offers.

Job Management & Scheduling

Queue exports, schedule them for off-hours, retry failures automatically. Enterprise-grade job management for large-scale migrations with hundreds of VMs.

REST API (238+ Endpoints)

Full programmatic control over every aspect of the export process. Integrate with your CI/CD pipelines, monitoring systems, or custom automation. OpenAPI documented.

Web Dashboard

Visual management of providers, jobs, and exports. Real-time progress, logs, and status. No CLI required for day-to-day operations — though the CLI is there when you need it.

Platform9 escape strategy: hypersdk connects to the OpenStack API layer that Platform9 runs on top of. It exports VMs using standard OpenStack calls — no Platform9-specific API needed. Your VMs come out as standard disk images ready for hyper2kvm conversion.

hyper2kvm — The Conversion Engine

The Python toolkit that converts exported VMs into production-ready KVM guests.

VMCraft Offline Disk Manipulation

Pure Python + qemu-nbd engine performs all guest fixes without booting the VM or requiring a libguestfs appliance. Faster, lighter, and works in constrained environments.

Windows VirtIO Driver Injection

Three-layer firstboot mechanism (rhsrvany + Run key + Startup folder) ensures VirtIO drivers are installed on Windows guests. SATA disk bus for immediate boot, VirtIO upgrade post-migration.

initramfs/dracut Regeneration

Rebuilds the initial ramdisk with KVM-appropriate drivers (virtio_blk, virtio_net, virtio_scsi). The VM boots on KVM without the "dracut timeout" that kills most migrations.

fstab UUID Stabilization

Fixes device-name-based mount entries (e.g., /dev/sda1) to UUID-based mounts. Prevents boot failures when device naming changes between hypervisors.

GRUB Bootloader Repair

Updates GRUB configuration to reference correct devices and modules for KVM. Handles both BIOS and UEFI boot paths, including Secure Boot awareness.

Netplan NIC Wildcard Fix

Replaces hardcoded VMware NIC names (ens33, ens160) with wildcard match patterns. Network comes up automatically on KVM without manual reconfiguration.

Web dashboard: 75+ API endpoints power a full management interface — VM lifecycle, disk operations, guest agent insights, security analysis, capacity planning, and more. This is what replaces the Platform9 dashboard after your jailbreak.

Migration Steps

Six steps from Platform9 captivity to KVM freedom. Most migrations complete in hours, not weeks.

1. **Install the Tools**
   `pip install hyper2kvm` for the conversion engine. `go install hypersdk` for the export daemon. Both install in under a minute with zero external dependencies beyond Python 3.10+ and Go 1.22+.

2. **Export from Platform9**
   `hyperexport --provider openstack --vm my-vm --output /tmp/export` — hypersdk connects to the OpenStack layer beneath Platform9 and exports your VM's disk images with full progress streaming. Works with any OpenStack credentials.

3. **Convert & Deploy**
   `h2kvmctl --vmdk /tmp/export/disk.qcow2 --emit-domain-xml --virsh-define` — converts the disk image, applies all offline fixes (initramfs, fstab, GRUB, network), generates libvirt XML, and defines the VM in one command.

4. **Verify**
   Open `https://host:5070` in your browser to see the VM running in the hyper2kvm web dashboard. All 20+ panels are live: CPU, memory, disk I/O, network, guest agent info, security analysis.

5. **Repeat for Remaining VMs**
   Use batch mode for fleet migrations: define all VMs in a YAML file and let hyper2kvm process them in parallel. The zkvm TUI provides a guided wizard for operators who prefer interactive workflows.

6. **Decommission Platform9**
   Once all VMs are running on self-managed KVM, cancel your Platform9 subscription. Save $150,000/year (50 nodes) or $450,000 over three years. Redirect budget to hardware, talent, or other projects.

Risk mitigation: Run both Platform9 and self-managed KVM in parallel during migration. Verify each VM works on KVM before decommissioning it on Platform9. Zero downtime, zero data loss.

Ready to Break Free?

Stop paying for management of infrastructure you already own. The tools are free. The path is proven.

10m

Install Time

pip install + go install. Both tools ready in under ten minutes on any Linux system.

3

Steps to Migrate

Export, convert, deploy. Each VM migrates with a single command per step.

20+

Dashboard Panels

Full VM management UI replaces Platform9's dashboard. No feature gap.

$0

Licensing Cost

Apache-2.0 open source. Free forever. No per-node fees. No subscriptions.

Get Started Today

hyper2kvm: `github.com/ssahani/hyper2kvm`
hypersdk: `github.com/ssahani/hypersdk`

Schedule a migration assessment — we'll analyze your Platform9 deployment and provide a step-by-step jailbreak plan tailored to your environment.